

Enculturation across five settings: outline of results

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1 Questions

- Danescu-Niculescu-Mizil et al. [3] (DNM13) found that beer-forum members’ language first moves toward the community’s and then away as they become veterans. Does this generalize to other communities?
- *How* does enculturation happen? Which feedback (corrections, mockery, rule pointers, silence, moderation, reviewer requests, editors’ revisions) changes what a person does next?

2 Takeaways

1. **DNM13’s curve replicates only where the community writes one kind of text.** It appears in nine corpora: BeerAdvocate and RateBeer (early convergence +0.09 and +0.15 bits on the paper’s own population), the review posts of r/bourbon (+0.32) and r/Scotch (+0.06), shave-of-the-day posts in r/wicked_edge (+0.76), and the review posts of r/cigars, r/fragrance, r/rum and r/worldwhisky (raw drops of 0.2–0.7 bits, too few heavy users to test). It is absent in 80 hobby subreddits, 14 political and conspiratorial subreddits, Voat, 4chan /pol/, journalists changing outlet or desk, and 30,000 academics changing field. What is learned in the genre corpora is mostly the opening template. Every replicating corpus is far more register-homogeneous than every conversational one (Fig. 5), but homogeneity does not order the size of the effect, and r/wallstreetbets has one register and no convergence: a shared written genre is necessary, not sufficient.
2. **No feedback we observed changes what a newcomer writes next; feedback changes whether they stay.** No cue, explicit (“why did you say it like that?”) or implicit (no response), predicts adoption of a convention on the next post. Directives are not followed, except “post this elsewhere”. A reviewer’s request leaves little trace on a newcomer’s next paper (+0.01 SD in the 2024 cohort, +0.08 in 2025 with a different text pipeline). Editors’ post-publication edits do not fall with experience, and a published correction, the one explicit public sanction a journalist gets, is followed by more corrections, not fewer. Overt criticism draws argument in the same thread, then unchanged writing. What feedback does move is retention: a clarifying question keeps newcomers (+10 points on returning within 30 days), moderation removes them (−7), and any reply buys one more turn, on hobby, political and conspiratorial forums and on 4chan alike. Of the prior-work mechanisms, generics, pedagogy, norm profiles, convention-formation metrics and rational rule learning find nothing in field data.
3. **Tacit aspects of enculturation: newcomers are never behind on the written rules, only on the unwritten register, and that gap closes slowly within person.** A classifier

that tells newcomers’ posts from veterans’ is at chance on stated conventions (review templates, style-guide rules, checklist practices) from the first post; on register, length and vocabulary it starts at AUC 0.64–0.79 and falls to 0.52–0.56 for the same people after about 100 Reddit posts, and modestly over a journalist’s first 50–200 articles. At ICLR the gap exists only for teams with no prior ICLR author.

4. **In professional domains newcomers arrive looking like insiders, or *more* like insiders, before settling at a normal distance.** Journalists switch house style at the move; Guardian newcomers’ residual deviations from the public style guide (2.5 points, mostly -ize spellings by commissioned and overseas contributors) never shrink within person; academics switch fields in one step; newcomers to ICLR from physics or statistics write first papers whose practices and writing sit at the field’s level, and only teams with no prior ICLR author fall short, a gap that closes as a coauthor gains papers.

Units. *Genre corpus*: the review posts of a subreddit (review flair or title, or two or more section headers). *Conversational community*: all posts of a subreddit. *Bits*: cross-entropy per token under the community’s monthly bigram model (lower = more like the community that month). *Points*: percentage points. *Volume*: posts in the following 90 days. *SD*: standard deviations of a practice dimension across ICLR papers. *OR*: odds ratio.

3 Data

Table 1 lists the corpora. Gray cells mark settings where the feedback newcomers receive is not in the data (“silent feedback”).

Table 1: Corpora. Gray cells: feedback not observed.

Corpus (source, size)	How a newcomer arrives	Action space	Feedback observed	Newcomer sample
Beer review sites: BeerAdvocate 1.59M, RateBeer 2.92M reviews (McAuley dumps)	first review on the site	wording, jargon, review structure	not observed	users with 50+ reviews
Reddit: 116 subreddits, 2005–2025 [26]	first post in the subreddit; account age and self-identification split cohorts	wording, format, title tags, sign-offs, headers, where to post	replies, votes, removals, AutoModerator, moderator notices	80 conversational communities; 7 review-genre subsets; 24k labelled early posts, 15k pre-adoption events

Corpus (source, size)	How a newcomer arrives	Action space	Feedback observed	Newcomer sample
Fringe forums: 14 political and conspiratorial subreddits (r/politics 217M posts, The_Donald 53M, r/conspiracy 45M, r/Conservative 23M, ten smaller ones); Voat, 7 subverses incl. GreatAwakening, QRV, pizzagate, 8.6M posts 2013–2020 [16]; 4chan /pol/, 45M posts 2016–17 [17]	first post; no persistent identity on /pol/ or Voat’s QRV	wording, format, where to post	replies, quotes (/pol/), votes, insults; rule pointers only where moderated	12 subreddits and 6 subverses with DNM13 runs; 144k newcomer sibling pairs
ICLR peer review: 2020–2026 papers, reviews, PDFs; OpenReview profiles and submission histories	first ICLR submission, verified against all prior OpenReview submissions	experimental practices (baselines, datasets, ablations, error bars, statistical tests, code, limitations, theory); abstract language	reviews (15k coded for 2024, 16k for 2025), rebuttals (44k requests), score changes, decisions	5,723 first-time 2024 authors, 1,730 returning in 2025; 9,135 first-time 2025 authors, 3,013 returning in 2026
Academics: OpenAlex works indexed in arXiv, 2005–2026, 2.1M used	first works in a new arXiv field after a majority elsewhere	abstract conventions (openings, hedging, structure, passive voice)	not observed	30,306 field movers (193,832 authors); first-author subsets
News articles: All the News 2.0 [2], 1.58M bylined; NYT Archive 898k with desk; newssniffer revision histories, 87,556 NYT and 221k Guardian	move to a new outlet, section or desk; first article in the corpus	house style, 295 Guardian style-guide rules, sourcing practices, LM distance	not observed (pre-publication edits are not captured); published corrections (11,307 Guardian amendment notes)	151 outlet movers, 48 section movers, 253 desk movers, 10,250 Guardian newcomers
NewsEdits [22]: 17 outlets, 268k version pairs with edit-intention labels	as above	as above	post-publication revisions by editors; editor names at Reuters and AP	3,097 journalists at NYT, 1,669 at the Guardian
SWE-chat [19]: 5,851 developer–assistant sessions, 2.7M turns	a developer’s first session with the tool	prompts to an AI coding assistant	the developer’s pushback (58k annotated prompts)	186 developers

4 Behavioural reinforcement analyses

- Retention on Reddit: a clarification request +10 points on returning within 30 days and +16% volume; moderation −7 points and −25% volume; an informative reply +3 points per level. All survive propensity adjustment and label-noise correction.
- Silence: a reply buys one more turn in the same thread (+30 points, matched siblings) and nothing beyond it, for veterans too; any reply beats none by 15–21 points on 30-day return. Silence is the strongest predictor of leaving and does not teach: a reply does not predict adopting

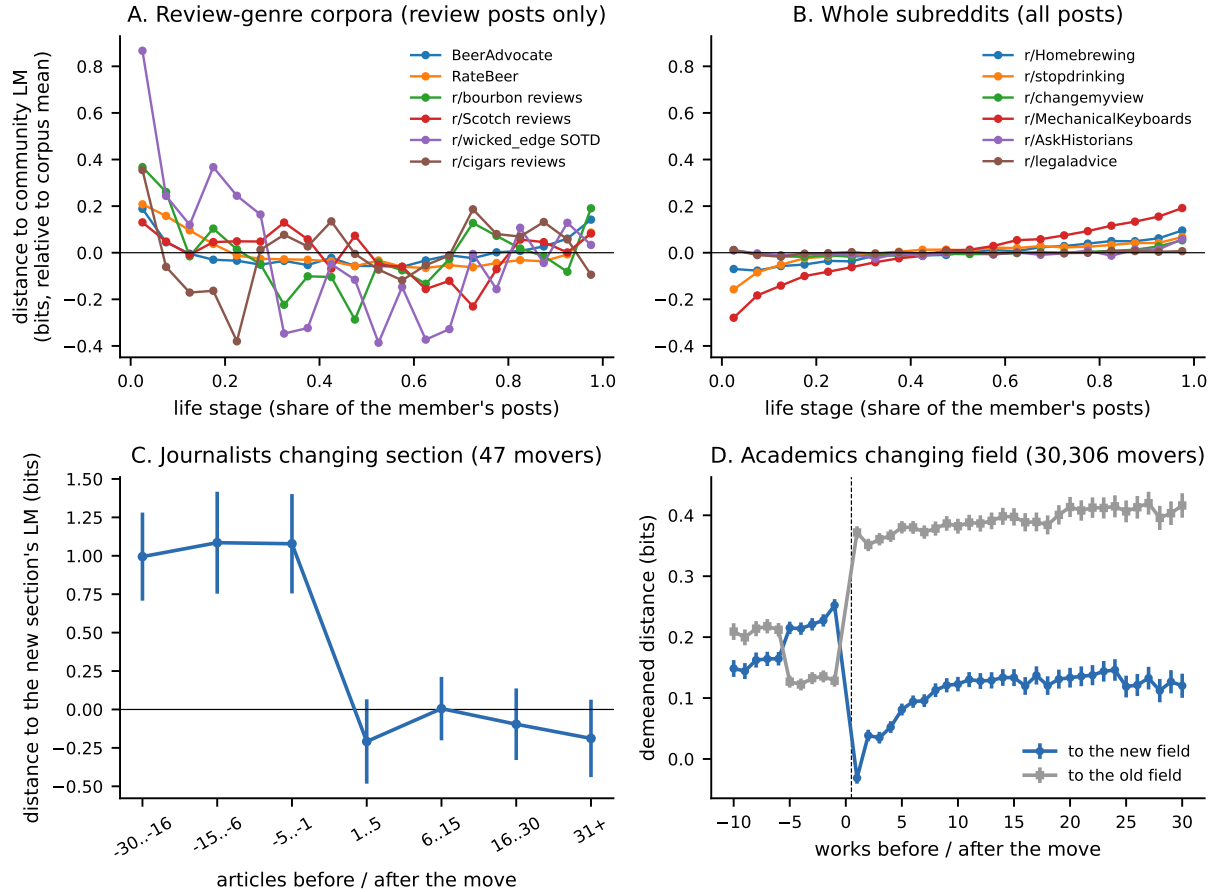


Figure 1: Where the DNM13 curve appears, and where entry is a step. A, B: distance to the community’s snapshot language model by life stage (share of a member’s posts), users with 50+ posts, relative to each corpus’s mean; review-genre corpora (A) show the early drop, whole subreddits (B) only the late rise, whose lift of the corpus mean is why early bins sit below zero. C, D: journalists’ distance to the new section’s language by article bin (C) and academics’ demeaned distance to the new and old field by work index (D) both drop at the move and stay flat.

a convention next time (OR 0.7–1.4 across 19 conventions). A rational-learner model says why: one review read carries 0.02–2.8 bits about a norm, the response to one’s own post 0.001–0.009 bits, because conforming and non-conforming posts draw the same replies; fitted feedback weights are near zero and beliefs are flat from the first to the tenth review. The arrival of a reviewer request at ICLR is equally uninformative (0.00–0.01 bits); what differs there is that the request names the practice and the score depends on answering it. Rejected posts draw no replies, so a newcomer never sees a negative example.

- Modelling: a reply that itself uses the convention predicts adoption, in the same thread only. Selective copying toward well-received and senior partners is present but small.
- Directive “post elsewhere”: +13.5 points move to the recurring thread (16% vs 2.5%), positive in 7 of 8 forums. No other directive is followed (Fig. 8, appendix).
- ICLR: promised changes made within the cycle 52% vs 28% unrequested; rating raised for 16% of mostly-promised reviews vs 0% with no response; acceptance +8 points for promising, −18

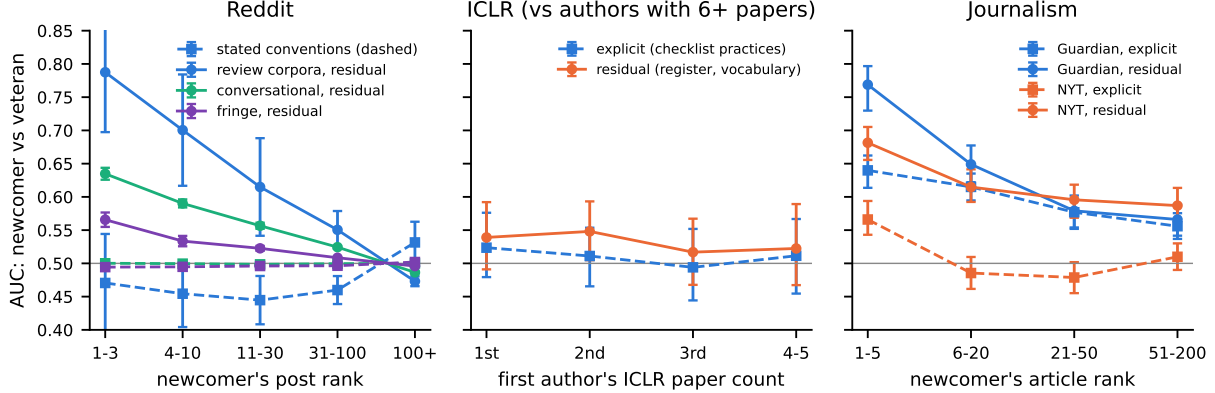


Figure 2: Tacit aspects of enculturation: how well a classifier tells newcomers’ work from veterans’ (AUC, 0.5 = indistinguishable), by tenure, using only the stated conventions (dashed) or only the residual register, length and vocabulary (solid). Newcomers are never behind on the written rules; the residual gap closes with tenure on Reddit and in journalism; at ICLR a typical first paper is already at the veteran level.

for pushback. Rejected newcomers return at 23% vs 35% if accepted (2025 cohort 30% vs 38%) and change more when they do.

- Fringe forums: the DNM13 curve is absent (14 subreddits, median -0.002 bits; Voat -0.07 to $+0.02$), and a reply buys one more turn there too ($+27$ points for newcomers; being quoted on $/pol/$ $+13$). What changes is the sanction register: insults in 6.7% of replied newcomer posts on fringe subreddits, 14% on Voat and 19% on $/pol/$ against 1.9% in hobby communities, replacing rule pointers ($4.3\% \rightarrow 1.1\%$ and 0.6%); corrections (2–3%) and clarification requests (3%) are the same everywhere.
- Everything that produced no effect is in Appendix B.

5 Tacit aspects of enculturation

What we did (Fig. 2):

- Split each setting’s conventions into *explicit* (what a rulebook states: review templates and format cues on Reddit, the 295 machine-checkable Guardian style rules and 11 NYT conventions, the ICLR checklist practices) and *residual* (register from function words and layout, vocabulary, sourcing and hedging, with the explicit features regressed out).
- Test 1, the gap and its closing: a classifier tells newcomers’ work from veterans’ in the same community, year and post type (cross-validated by person) using only the explicit set or only the residual; AUC by tenure, cross-sectionally and within person against the member’s own later work.
- Test 2, psychometric: a two-parameter item-response model, $P(x_{ij} = 1 \mid \theta_i) = \sigma(a_j(\theta_i - b_j))$, where $x_{ij} = 1$ if respondent i (a member at one tenure stage: posts 1–5, 6–20, 21–50, 51+) used convention j in at least one post where it applied; $\theta_i \sim N(0, 1)$ is latent competence, b_j the item’s difficulty (the competence at which use is a coin flip) and a_j its discrimination (how steeply use rises with competence). Fitted by marginal maximum likelihood with θ integrated out on a Gauss–Hermite grid; competence by stage is the posterior mean of θ ; at ICLR b_j carries subfield and paper-type covariates. An item is tacit-like when it is not in the rulebook, b_j is

high and a_j is high. Recovery checks refit the model on data simulated from the fit.

- Test 3, knowing-when: the veterans’ context-conditional policy (header given post type and length; style rule inside vs outside a direct quote and by section; practice given paper type) against the unconditional rate; a member’s fit to the conditional policy by tenure.
- Test 4, reaction prediction: whether members move toward what the audience rewards (a community reward model on Reddit; reviewer requests at equal practice level at ICLR).

What we found:

- On the explicit set newcomers are at chance from their first post or paper (AUC 0.45–0.52 on Reddit and ICLR; Guardian 0.64 and NYT 0.57, both carried by hiring: -ize spellings and British vs American forms).
- On the residual the gap is large at entry (review corpora 0.79, conversational 0.64, Guardian 0.77, NYT 0.68) and closes within person: about 100 posts on Reddit (0.77 $\rightarrow$ 0.56 by posts 31–49), modestly over a journalist’s first 50–200 articles (0.58 $\rightarrow$ 0.53; register and sourcing move, vocabulary does not). At ICLR a typical first paper is already at the veteran level (0.52–0.54); only all-newcomer teams differ (0.63; -0.21 SD in the IRT; $+0.35$ reviewer requests per review), and that gap closes as a coauthor gains papers.
- The IRT latent is vocabulary breadth on Reddit (grows with tenure only in the whisky communities), house English in journalism (no within-person gain), and the empirical-claims register at ICLR (flat across stages). Headers and most written rules are easy and barely discriminating; a handful of items look tacit (chill filtration, a cigar’s foot and cap, the Guardian’s onto/on to and over/more than).
- Knowing-when gives veterans no advantage anywhere; Reddit veterans use headers in the same contexts at the same rate but write more where headers are not used.
- Reddit users move toward what earns upvotes (two thirds of the actual rise in score over posts 1–20, in 15 of 16 communities) without getting better at predicting a post’s reception; ICLR authors do not anticipate reviewer requests on the next paper.
- What goes with the closing on Reddit (per-post tacit score, change over the next five posts, within user, 3.97M posts): not feedback. Corrections, rule pointers, mockery, welcomes, instruction and modelling replies all go with a *slower* drop (the posts that draw teaching replies stay newcomer-like); only upvotes and clarification requests go with a faster one, and a matched-sibling test of reply vs silence gives zero. Of the prior-work mechanisms, breadth of interaction (more distinct partners, CHAI) and exposure to senior and well-received posts above one’s own in the thread (selective copying) go with a faster drop; cultural accumulation (join-year cohort) and audience design do not. At least 70% of the closing survives partialling out post type, topic, year, dropping post 1 and restricting to survivors.
- Robustness: against a member’s own posts 100+ (articles 400+) the closing flattens at post 50 in conversational Reddit and by articles 21–50 in journalism, so it is learning rather than drift; in the review corpora the AUC keeps falling after post 50 at a quarter of the earlier rate, so at most two thirds of the early closing there is learning. Partialling out or matching on length and section keeps 90–100% of the gap and its closing (the NYT closing shrinks to three quarters under matching); explicit features stay at 0.50 under every variant; four fringe subreddits show the conversational shape at half the size.

6 Does richer behavioural convergence happen?

Beyond language: do journalists who switch outlets adopt the new outlet’s sourcing practices, and do academics who switch into ML adopt ICLR’s experimental practices? Mostly not (Table 2,

Practice	Newcomers' first work	Change afterwards
ICLR experimental practices	outsiders within 0.06 SD of ML-native newcomers; differences follow subfield	+0.03 to +0.06 SD by the next paper; requests carry over for theory (+0.13) and error bars (+0.11)
ICLR, first author from outside CS/ML (178 papers)	at the field mean ($-0.01 z$)	+0.02 SD; request effect +0.07 ($p = 0.13$)
Journalism sourcing (named, anonymous, document and expert sources, quote share, attribution)	movers close 46% (outlet), 69% (section), 54% (desk) of the gap at the move, against 92–100% for surface style	no gradual phase; no sourcing practice moves by more than 0.08 SD over 30 articles
Academic abstract conventions (openings, hedging, structure)	19–25% switch at the move	1–4% gradually; first-author movers no different
Guardian public style guide (295 rules, 83% precision) vs NYT (11 conventions)	Guardian newcomers 2.5 points below veterans, 93% of the excess in -ize spellings; NYT newcomers at the veteran level	within person -0.2 points (Guardian), $+0.4$ (NYT); the desk corrects toward the guide after publication (12,558 fixes vs 788 reversals) but fixes newcomers' violations less often (3.9 vs 7.4 per 100)
Published corrections (Guardian, 6.1% of articles)	newcomers corrected less (4.9% vs 6.2%), same error mix	no within-person change; after a first correction another follows more often (66% vs 57% within 20 articles), nothing else moves

Table 2: Deeper practices: arrival level and change.

Fig. 3).

7 Prior methods

Mechanisms from the cognitive-science literature on conventions (Goodman and related work); 18 have an empirical analogue in our data (Table 3).

Table 3: Mechanisms from the convention-learning literature, tested in field data.

Method	Why we used it	What we found	Found in field data?
Audience design (RSA) [11, 4]	Veterans should adapt to newcomers	Veterans explain more to newcomers, and use more jargon with them	Yes
Partner-specific vs community conventions (CHAI, 13)	One partner's usage yields partner-specific expectations; community adoption needs several partners	A reply that models a convention predicts adoption only in the same thread (OR 2.0 vs 1.0); exposure from several partners predicts <i>less</i> adoption than repeated exposure from one	Yes, within a thread
Selective social learning [12]	Newcomers copy well-received and senior partners	Later style aligns more with high-scoring and veteran partners in 57 of 72 communities; small	Yes, small
Cultural accumulation [18, 25]	Later cohorts inherit more	Later cohorts start slightly more fluent, scaling with archive size	Yes, weak

Method	Why we used it	What we found	Found in field data?
Mixed-effects transformers [28]	A neural replacement for the bigram model	Community prefix predicts later posts better only in whisky reviews; user prefixes do not move toward the community	Agrees with the bigram result
Politeness as competing utilities [29]	Informativeness and kindness should trade off	Informative replies retain (+3 points per level); kindness adds nothing; neither affects adoption	Partial
Irony and mockery; clarification questions [15, 27]	Non-literal sanction and informative questions as feedback	Mockery: no effect. Clarification requests: +10 points retention, no adoption effect	Partial
Context and abstraction level [14]	Finer distinctions need finer terms	Granularity unrelated to how often a community compares items; users adapt specificity between sibling communities	Mixed
Comparison classes [24]	Gradable standards are community-relative	Price thresholds differ by community; newcomers do not recalibrate	Descriptive only
Simulated responders [8]	Propensity model and counterfactual replies	Propensity adjustment leaves every cue effect unchanged; a trained responder reproduces the cue mix but not content	Used as a control
Controlled test sets [6, 7]	Validate the cue labeller on minimal pairs	Near-perfect on moderation, rule pointers, mockery, clarification; 0.82 on corrections; results survive noise correction	Validation only
Convention-formation metrics [1, 10]	Convergence, reduction, group specificity; faster with more interaction	Term similarity to veterans rises only by composition; no reduction; interaction thickness predicts nothing	No
Generics [23]	“We don’t do X here” conveys norms	Present in half of replies; no effect on adoption (OR 1.04)	No
Norm profiles from demonstrations [21, 5]	Compress a community’s responses into a stated norm	Profiles add 0.017 bits for predicting removal; newcomer compliance flat over 20 posts	No
Pedagogy [20]	Instruction should speed learning	Instruction in half of replies; no effect on adoption (OR 0.92)	No
Rational rule learning [9]	Format rules as concepts learned from examples	A learner fed what newcomers saw cannot beat the base rate: rejected posts draw no replies and are never seen	No, and explains why

8 Contrast: correcting an AI

Developers push back on a coding assistant in 42% of prompts (72% of sessions), almost never with hostility (0.4%); only 8% corrects a term or convention, the rest redirects the task, and the rate does not fall within or across sessions (Fig. 9, appendix). On Reddit one replied newcomer post in eight to ten draws an explicit negative remark (about 6% corrections, 9% rule pointers), mockery one in fifty; silent sanctions (downvotes, removals) are three times as common as spoken ones.

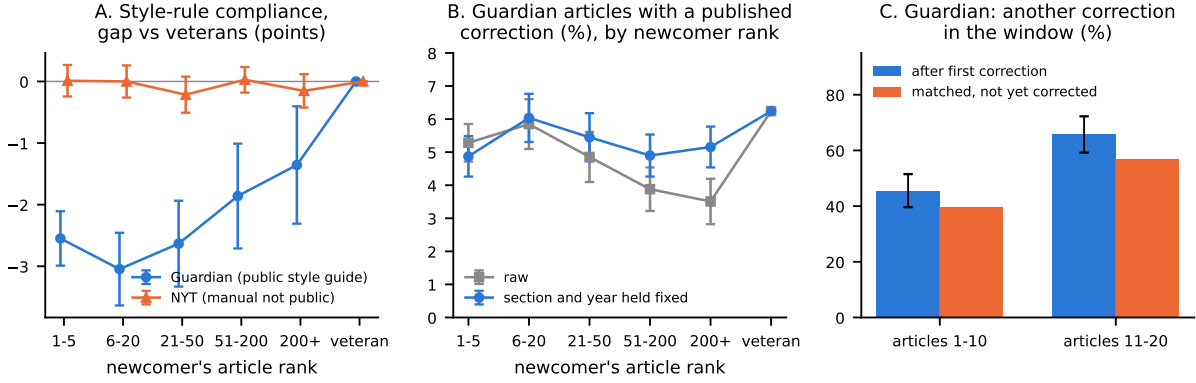


Figure 3: Journalism: style rules and published corrections by the newcomer’s article rank (first published version; 95% intervals). A: compliance with the outlet’s own style rules, points below veterans; the Guardian’s narrowing with rank is who stays, since within person the gap does not move. B: share of Guardian articles carrying a published correction, raw and with section and year held fixed. C: another correction in the next 10 or 20 articles after a journalist’s first, against matched journalists not yet corrected.

9 Machine enculturation: a first demo

An LLM newcomer run through the same measures as the human newcomers (Fig. 4; design in the notes): five communities, 30 posts in real threads of one simulated year, with exposure (40 community posts in context), peer feedback (replies to its own posts), operator feedback (moderator notes), reward (scores) and explicit norms (the rules or template) switched on or off; Qwen3-14B-Base, Qwen3-14B, Qwen3-32B; an OLMo-2-7B post-training ladder (base, SFT, DPO, Instruct); a dose-response grid on Qwen3-1.7B-Base; and an 8-agent swarm.

- Written rules are followed at once (template use +0.40 for the 14B pair; the 32B is at ceiling). No channel produces learning over 30 posts: peer feedback, operator notes and reward move neither register, template use nor the tacit score; exposure lowers the LM distance by 0.06–0.15 bits and shortens posts. The agents’ tacit score starts at 0.45–0.47, below the level human newcomers reach after 30 posts (0.52 → 0.48), and stays flat.
- Base vs post-trained is mostly format: the same Qwen3-14B weights score 7.7 bits in the base model’s plain-text format, 8.0 as the base model and 8.7 in chat format. Post-training does raise the “help others” goal share (0.36–0.44 vs 0.15 for human newcomers) and removes joking.
- Along the OLMo-2 ladder, responsiveness to the operator grows with preference tuning (words per post after a moderator note: −1, −8, −24, −23 for base, SFT, DPO, Instruct), LM distance rises (7.9 → 9.5 bits) and template use rises (0.37 → 0.89). Exposure training on 1k–10k community posts lowers LM distance by 0.16 bits and leaves the tacit score unchanged; DPO on upvote-ranked reply pairs barely trains (preference accuracy 0.58–0.66) and moves nothing.
- Silence, the strongest human exit signal (84% continue vs 92% after a reply), does nothing to the agent: it continues after silence 99.4% of the time and never leaves.
- Swarm: no collaboration on a shared help-desk task (coverage 0.47–0.50, below random assignment at 0.66 and a single agent at 1.0, no improvement over 50 rounds), reference-game accuracy falling (0.74 → 0.64) with lengthening messages, yet conventions form: group-specific labels, a channel-wide name adopted by an agent injected at round 25 every time, and a population convention in 6 of 6 naming-game runs, tipped by a committed minority at 25–30% for Qwen3-14B

(humans about 25%) and 40–50% for Qwen3-32B. The swarm’s register drifts away from the community (9.4 $\rightarrow$ 9.7 bits vs 8.6 for human comments) and homogenises; agents never sanction or route each other.

10 Caveats

- Genre corpora rest on 16–430 heavy users each; the per-person test flags only large drops, so per-person shares are lower bounds.
- Reply labels come from one model (Qwen3-32B), validated on templated items; embedded corrections are mostly missed.
- Rebuttal effects are upper bounds (authors choose what to promise); initial ratings are reconstructed. The 2026 ICLR texts are mid-cycle versions read with a different pipeline.
- Revision histories start after publication; the pre-publication edit is invisible. Directive extraction recall is about 60%.

11 Still running / next

- ICLR 2025 $\rightarrow$ 2026: re-extract practices from camera-ready PDFs when OpenReview access returns; code the 2025 author responses.
- 4chan /pol/ 2017–2019 not prepared; a human check of 100 rebuttal stance labels.

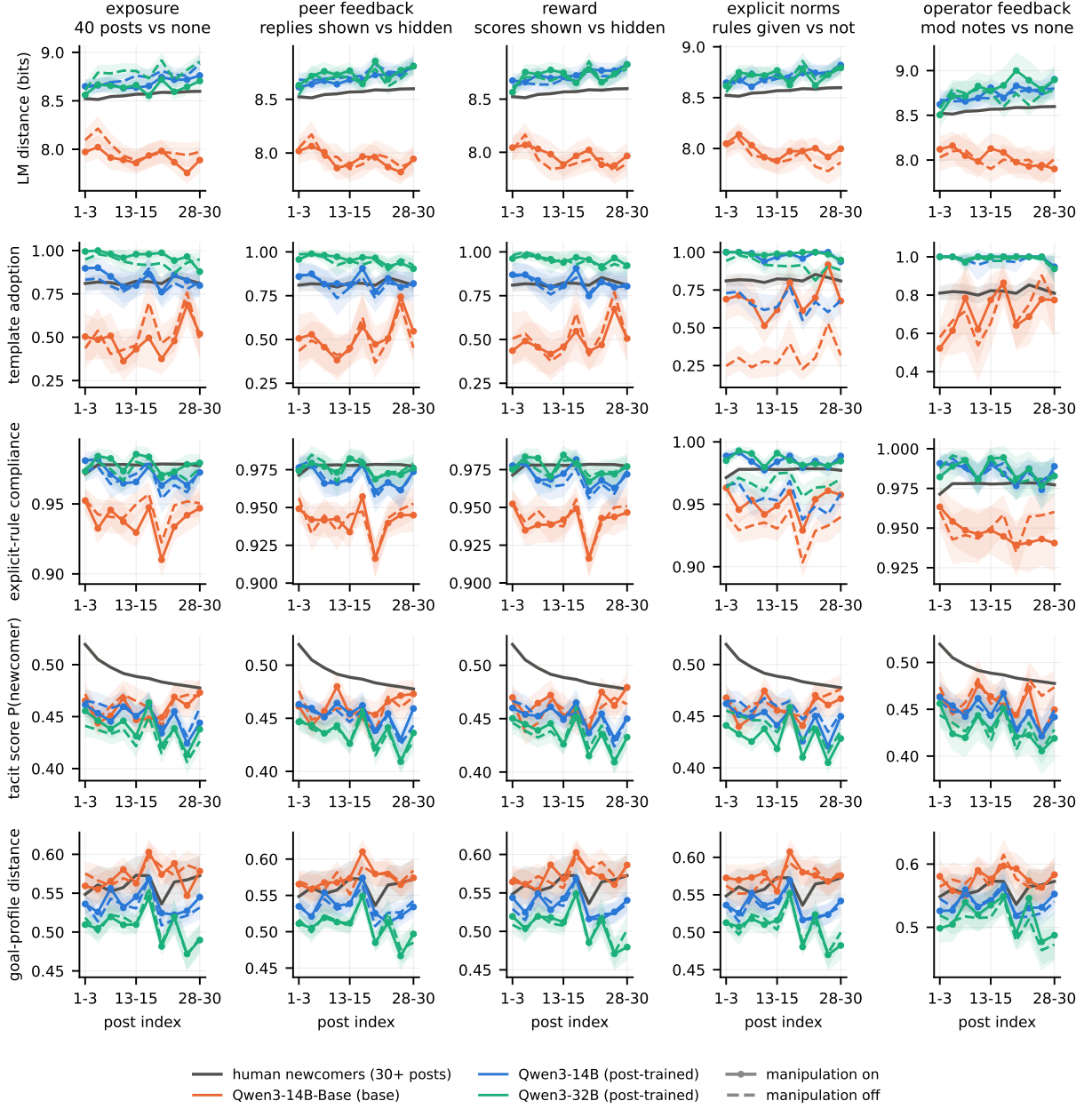


Figure 4: Machine newcomers against human newcomers on the same measures, by post index: LM distance, template adoption, rule compliance and the tacit score, under each manipulation (solid: on; dashed: off) for a base and a post-trained model. Only written rules move the agents, and nothing moves the tacit score.

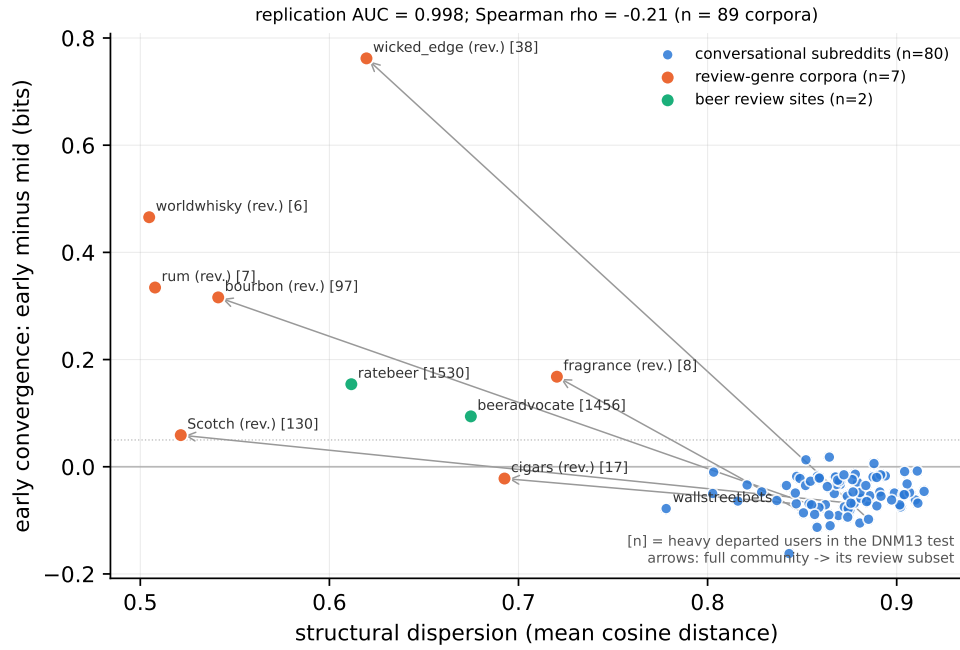


Figure 5: Shared register and the DNM13 curve. Each point is a corpus; x = how far posts sit from the corpus’s structural centroid (function words and layout; lower = one register), y = early convergence. Replicating corpora separate from conversational subreddits (AUC 0.998), but homogeneity does not order the size of the effect. Arrows join a community’s full post set to its review subset.

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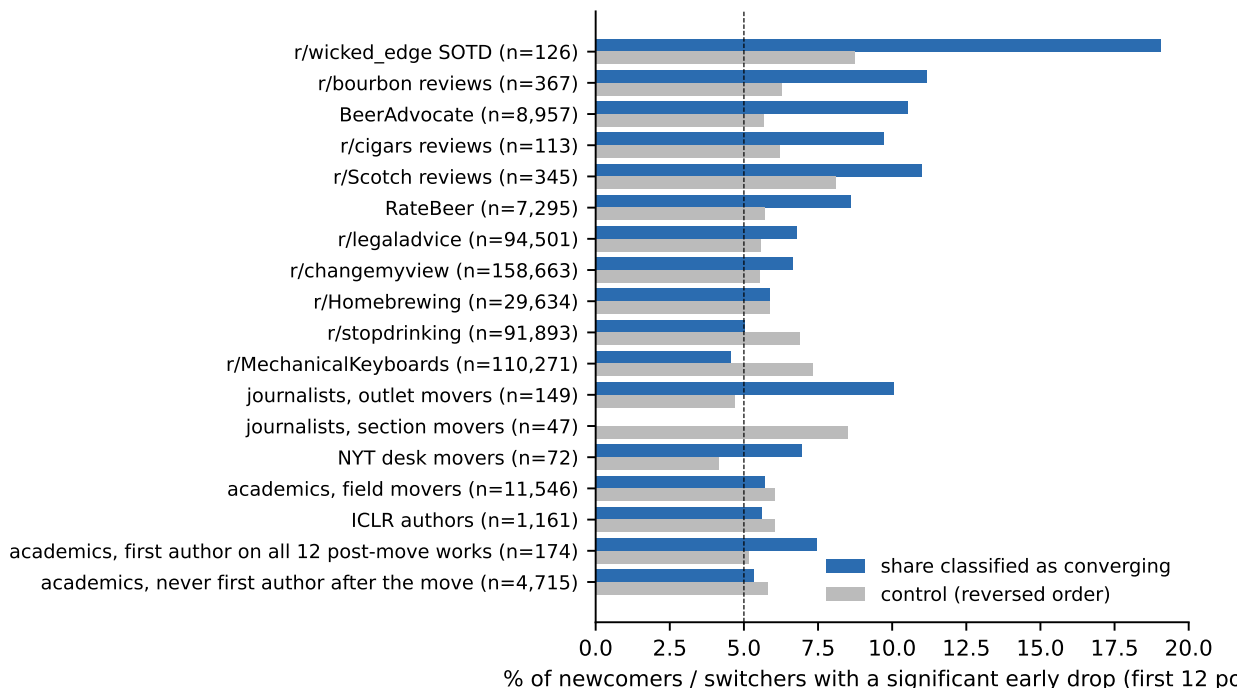


Figure 6: Share of newcomers (or switchers) whose own first 12 posts show a significant early drop, tested against shufflings of their own post order, beside the share flagged on the reversed order (the false-positive rate for that corpus). Dashed line: the nominal 5%.

A Convergence among subpopulations

- Reddit genre corpora: 10–19% of newcomers show the drop individually against 6–9% by chance; on the paper’s framing (heavy users, first fifth vs middle third of a career) 23–41% converge against 12–22% who diverge; a mixture estimate puts true convergers at 26% (bourbon), 36% (shaving), 15% (RateBeer), 13.5% (BeerAdvocate).
- Conversational communities: the share equals the control in all 103; where first posts are the most predictable (MechanicalKeyboards, churning, stopsmoking) divergers outnumber convergers two or three to one.
- Professional writers: outlet movers 10% vs 4.7% control (15 people, delayed switches); section and desk movers, academics, first-author academics and ICLR authors at chance. The arrival step dominates (0.2–1.2 bits at the move, then flat). Ten Guardian section movers step 0.72 bits at the move with no slope after; Guardian section natives do converge gradually (-0.19 bits from articles 1–5 to 16–30, $p < 0.001$), the one professional group with a within-person curve.
- With shrinkage (random-slopes mixed model and a noise-corrected distribution of each person’s drop), the net share of material convergers (drop above 0.3 bits minus drop below -0.3) is +11 to +22 points in the genre and beer corpora and 0 to -20 in conversational communities; individual slopes are two to three times more dispersed in the genre corpora. The sampling noise of a 12-post drop (0.7–1.0 bits) exceeds the true spread everywhere, which is why the per-person test flags only 10–19%. The mean per-person drop explains 83–89% of the variance in these shares across corpora.

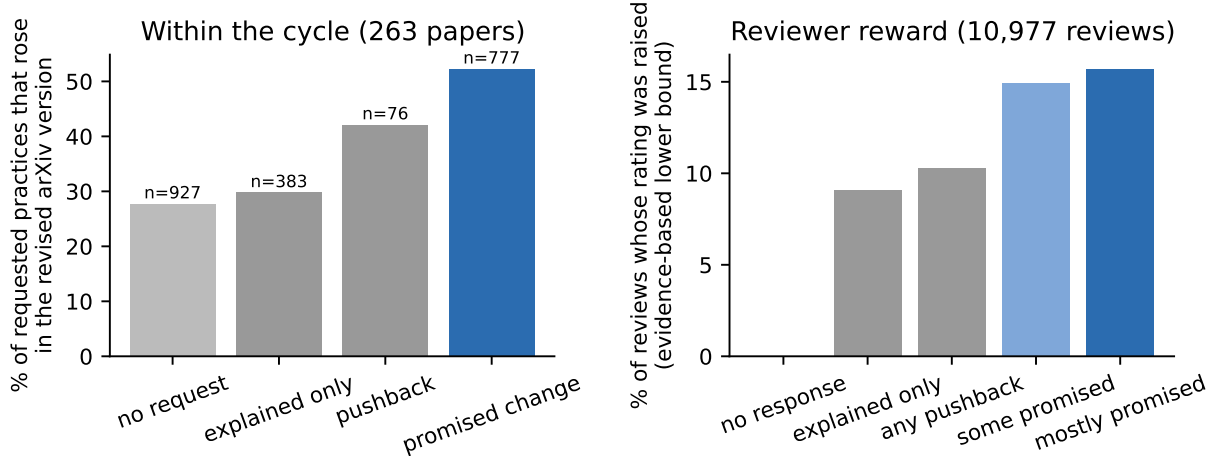


Figure 7: Peer review, where request, response, change and reward are all visible. Left: share of requested practices that rose in the revised arXiv version, by the authors’ stance. Right: share of reviews whose rating was raised, by how the authors answered that reviewer’s requests.

B Negative results

- Corrections, embedded corrections, rule pointers, mockery: no effect on retention, on jargon, question rate or language distance over the next five posts, or on adopting the convention next time (ORs 0.84–1.24, unchanged under propensity adjustment). Kindness beyond informativeness, generic norm statements and instruction: nothing.
- Content directives (more detail, a photo or log, a format, searching first, citing, asking clearly): -1.5 to $+3.6$ points; kind, informative or senior replies do not raise compliance. A newcomer’s “will do”: adoption 12.3% vs 12.7% with no reply.
- ICLR next paper: a reviewer’s request moves a genuine newcomer’s next paper by $+0.01$ SD (2024 $\rightarrow$ 2025, after removing 1,100 “newcomers” with earlier OpenReview submissions) and $+0.08$ (2025 $\rightarrow$ 2026; 4,008 papers, 16,207 reviews coded, 2026 versions from a mid-cycle mirror read with a different text pipeline); established authors $+0.05$ and $+0.06$. Theory and error-bar requests carry over in both cohorts; a shuffle of which paper got which request gives zero. Which newcomer value is right waits on the camera-ready 2026 texts.
- Editors: post-publication copy edits do not fall with experience (NYT; 7 NewsEdits outlets once calendar effects are held fixed; the Guardian’s own slope -0.31 per log article, $p = 0.23$), do not spike after a desk or section move, and at Reuters are 91% a property of the article. Newcomers’ articles get fewer edits because they are assigned briefs and op-eds.
- A public style guide: Guardian newcomers do not move toward the guide within person over their first 50 articles; the desk’s corrections toward the guide fall on veterans’ articles more than on newcomers’.
- Published corrections (11,307 Guardian amendment notes; detection precision and recall near 100%; 50% factual claims, 21% numbers and dates, 14% names): newcomers corrected less than veterans (4.9% vs 6.2%), same error mix, no within-person change. After a journalist’s first correction, another follows more often than for matched uncorrected journalists (66% vs 57% within 20 articles, the excess growing), the same error type recurs (names 29% vs 13%), and output, hedging, attribution, sourcing, departure and the desk’s editing of that journalist do not change. The NYT appends corrections to the captured text only until 2013, too thin to read.

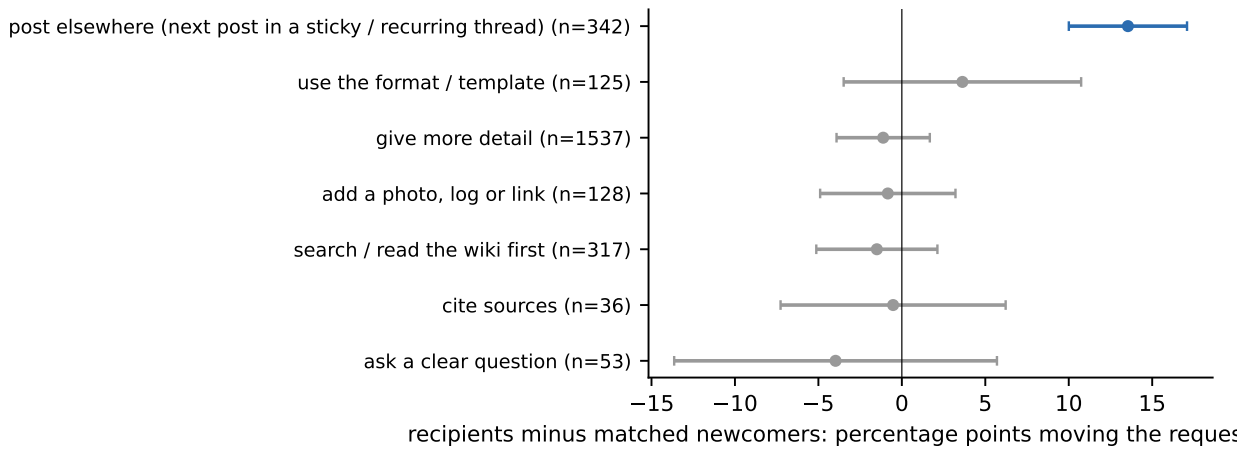


Figure 8: Does the newcomer do what the comment asked? Recipients of each directive compared with newcomers in the same forum and rank, matched on the pre-level of the feature. Only “post elsewhere” is followed.

- Overt criticism (a correction, rule pointer or mockery that is also unkind; 263 criticised users, 20 posts before and after, matched controls): no change in length, questions, hedging, politeness, profanity, scores, posting gaps or topics; the only trace is a few argumentative posts in the same thread.
- Emotional reactions to a cue (defensiveness, gratitude) move with the cue but mediate neither returning nor adoption.

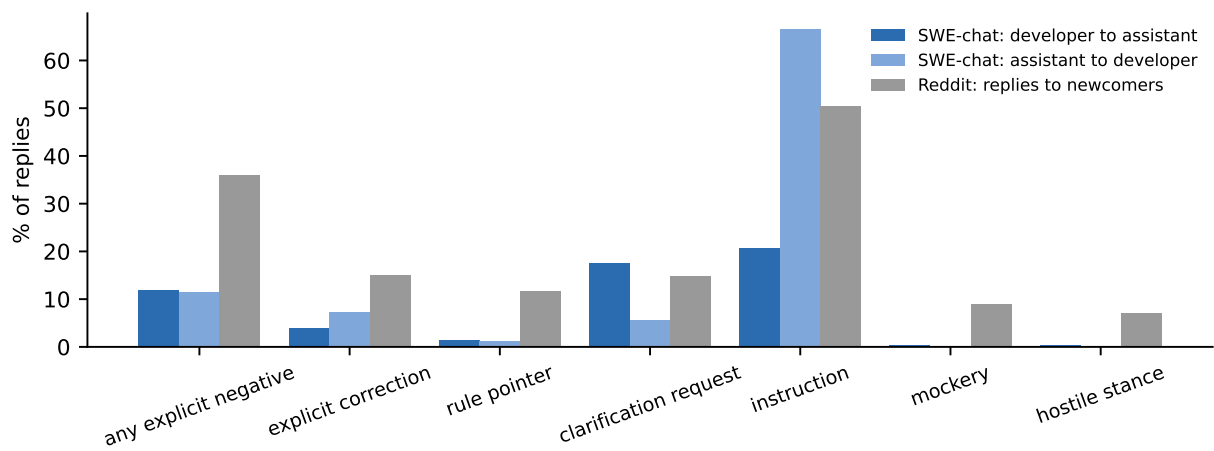


Figure 9: The same reply labels applied to developer–assistant exchanges (SWE-chat) and to replies to Reddit newcomers.